

New-Found Speed Makes Pelicans Mystery Entry In Southern Loop

By HALE MONTGOMERY
NEW ORLEANS (UP)— If a Southern Association opponent allows a Pelican on base this year, he may go all the way, and it is this new-found speed that New Orleans' "mystery entry" hopes will take them all the way to the pennant.

But a good many spots remain open at this late date, and even the New Orleans front office does not know the starting lineup. Quiet bargaining by newly-returned Vince Rizzo, general manager here five years ago, holds the key to filling in the holes.

The Pittsburgh Pirates and Hollywood of the Pacific Coast League are expected to come through by

the weekend with some of the badly-needed diamond talent.

Speed Is New

"We had home run hitters here several years ago and didn't win a pennant nor draw good crowds," Rizzo said. "We've had teams with outstanding pitching in the past, and didn't break any records. This year we'll have real speed. For a change, it may be a winner."

Rizzo, a Chicago Cub scout for the past five years, returns to the front office to work with field manager Andy Cohen, a happy combination that observers say will help the Pels.

"We'll have real speed, good defense and some outstanding pitching," Rizzo said. He seemed to think his bargaining, particular-

ly with Hollywood, will pay off handsomely with some veteran infield talent, and something close to outstanding in the hurling department.

Ignoring the attack for the moment, the Pels are very high on a fleet-footed shortstop up from the Eastern League from Williamsport, Pa., Dick Barone.

Barone displayed genuine speed on the base paths in the lower classification, stealing 26 bases, hit for a .264 average and was a standout defenseman.

Holes in Defense

First base and third base are unfilled, and the same holds for center field. Second base is in the doubtful category, with Earl Weaver, about the only face familiar from last year's sixth-place finishers, holding the inside track now.

The pitching looks pretty fine, depending, again, on Pittsburgh and Hollywood. Assuming the Pels get the men they want, the front line shapes up with Clarence Churn, a 13-8 hurler last year; Curt Rayden, a crafty righthander and tabbed "the best"; Donald Urquhart, a 5-4 hurler last year in an abbreviated season who has looked close to "brilliant" in spring workouts.

Along with this trio, Lenny Yochim, 12-8, will be back. Lefthander Harry Fisher, a strong hitter, rounds out the staff.

Catching, the "only spot I'm really worried about," is wide open. The Pelicans lost Danny Kravitz, now working out with the Pirates and leading the team in hitting on the spring exhibition swing.

The outfield has yet to jell. New Orleans opens against Mobile away from home Tuesday.

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